



# COMMON MISTAKES

## IN EXCEL INTERVIEWS



Just memorizing theory



Understand concepts with practical use



Relying only on VLOOKUP



Also use XLOOKUP / INDEX MATCH



Forgetting absolute reference



Understand (\$A\$1 vs A1) clearly



Not using Pivot Tables



Essential for fast and smart analysis



Analyzing data without cleaning



Clean data first – Garbage in = Garbage out



Ignoring data validation & checks



Use data validation, checks & filters



**TIP:**

Avoid mistakes. Work smart.  
Stand out in your Excel interview!



# RAPID FIRE

## EXCEL QUESTIONS

| #  | QUESTION                                                                                                                 | ANSWER                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  |  What does VLOOKUP do?                  | <b>Answer:</b><br>It looks for a value in the first column of a table and returns a value in the same row from a specified column.  |
| 2  |  What is Pivot Table used for?          | <b>Answer:</b><br>It is used to summarize, analyze, explore, and present large datasets.                                            |
| 3  |  What is the syntax of IF function?    | <b>Answer:</b><br>=IF(logical_test, value_if_true, value_if_false)                                                                 |
| 4  |  What is Absolute Reference?          | <b>Answer:</b><br>A cell reference that remains constant when copied. Example: \$A\$1                                             |
| 5  |  Difference between COUNT and COUNTA? | <b>Answer:</b><br>COUNT counts only numbers, COUNTA counts numbers and text.                                                      |
| 6  |  What is the use of TRIM function?    | <b>Answer:</b><br>It removes extra spaces from text, leaving only single spaces.                                                  |
| 7  |  What is the advantage of XLOOKUP?    | <b>Answer:</b><br>It can look up values in any direction, returns exact matches by default, and handles missing values better.    |
| 8  |  What is Conditional Formatting?      | <b>Answer:</b><br>It is used to apply formatting to cells based on specific conditions.                                           |
| 9  |  What is Data Validation?             | <b>Answer:</b><br>It is used to restrict the type of data or values that can be entered in a cell.                                |
| 10 |  What does Flash Fill do?             | <b>Answer:</b><br>It automatically fills data based on a pattern or example.                                                      |



**TIP:**

Practice daily, stay consistent and become an Excel expert!



# EXCEL FUNCTIONS

## CHEAT SHEET



### LOOKUP & REFERENCE

|               | FUNCTION                                                                     | SYNTAX                                                                                          | EXAMPLE                                                                                                  |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| VLOOKUP       | Looks for a value in the first column and returns a value from the same row. | =VLOOKUP(lookup_value, table_array, col_index, [range_lookup])                                  | =VLOOKUP(101, A2:D10, 4, FALSE)<br>→ Returns value from column 4 for ID 101                              |
| XLOOKUP       | Looks for a value in any direction and returns a match.                      | =XLOOKUP(lookup_value, lookup_array, return_array, [if_not_found], [match_mode], [search_mode]) | =XLOOKUP(101, A2:A10, D2:D10, "Not Found")<br>→ Returns value for ID 101 (or "Not Found" if not present) |
| INDEX         | Returns the value of a cell in a specific row and column.                    | =INDEX(array, row_num, [column_num])                                                            | =INDEX(B2:D10, 3, 2)<br>→ Returns value in 3rd row, 2nd column of the range B2:D10                       |
| MATCH         | Returns the relative position of an item in a range.                         | =MATCH(lookup_value, lookup_array, [match_type])                                                | =MATCH(101, A2:A10, 0)<br>→ Returns position of 101 in the range A2:A10                                  |
| INDEX + MATCH | Powerful combination for flexible lookups.                                   | =INDEX(return_range, MATCH(lookup_value, lookup_range, 0))                                      | =INDEX(D2:D10, MATCH(101, A2:A10, 0))<br>→ Returns value from column D for ID 101                        |



### LOGICAL

|         | FUNCTION                                                         | SYNTAX                                           | EXAMPLE                                                             |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| IF      | Returns a value if a condition is TRUE, otherwise another value. | =IF(logical_test, value_if_true, value_if_false) | =IF(B2>=50, "Pass", "Fail")<br>→ Returns "Pass" if B2 is 50 or more |
| IFERROR | Returns a value if a formula returns an error.                   | =IFERROR(value, value_if_error)                  | =IFERROR(VLOOKUP(101, A2:D10, 4, FALSE), "Not Found")               |
| AND     | Returns TRUE if all conditions are TRUE.                         | =AND(logical1, [logical2], ...)                  | =AND(B2>50, C2="Yes")<br>→ Returns TRUE if both conditions are TRUE |
| OR      | Returns TRUE if any one condition is TRUE.                       | =OR(logical1, [logical2], ...)                   | =OR(B2>50, C2="Yes")<br>→ Returns TRUE if any one condition is TRUE |



### TEXT

|                   | FUNCTION                                                    | SYNTAX                                                                         | EXAMPLE                                                                                      |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LEFT              | Returns the leftmost characters from a text string.         | =LEFT(text, [num_chars])                                                       | =LEFT("ExcelTips", 4)<br>→ Returns "Excel"                                                   |
| RIGHT             | Returns the rightmost characters from a text string.        | =RIGHT(text, [num_chars])                                                      | =RIGHT("ExcelTips", 4)<br>→ Returns "Tips"                                                   |
| MID               | Returns a specific number of characters from a text string. | =MID(text, start_num, num_chars)                                               | =MID("ExcelTips", 6, 4)<br>→ Returns "Tips"                                                  |
| CONCAT / TEXTJOIN | Joins text from multiple cells into one string.             | =CONCAT(text1, [text2], ...)<br>=TEXTJOIN(delimiter, ignore_empty, text1, ...) | =CONCAT(A2, " ", B2)<br>(TEXTJOIN(" ", TRUE, A2:C2))<br>→ Joins text with space or delimiter |



### MATH & STAT

|         | FUNCTION                                    | SYNTAX                               | EXAMPLE                                                               |
|---------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SUM     | Adds numbers in a range.                    | =SUM(number1, [number2], ...)        | =SUM(B2:B10)<br>→ Returns total of values in B2:B10                   |
| SUMIF   | Adds numbers based on a specific condition. | =SUMIF(range, criteria, [sum_range]) | =SUMIF(C2:C10, ">50", D2:D10)<br>→ Adds values in D2:D10 where C > 50 |
| COUNTIF | Counts cells based on a specific condition. | =COUNTIF(range, criteria)            | =COUNTIF(B2:B10, ">=50")<br>→ Counts cells with value 50 or more      |
| AVERAGE | Calculates the average of numbers.          | =AVERAGE(number1, [number2], ...)    | =AVERAGE(B2:B10)<br>→ Returns average of values in B2:B10             |



### DATA

|                             | FUNCTION                                         | SYNTAX                                                                                          | EXAMPLE                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SORT                        | Sorts data in ascending or descending order.     | =SORT(array, [sort_index], [sort_order])                                                        | =SORT(A2:D10, 2, -1)<br>→ Sorts by 2nd column in descending order                                                       |
| FILTER                      | Filters a range based on a condition.            | =FILTER(array, include, [if_empty])                                                             | =FILTER(A2:D10, B2:B10>50, "No Data")<br>→ Returns rows where B > 50                                                    |
| UNIQUE                      | Returns unique values from a range.              | =UNIQUE(array)                                                                                  | =UNIQUE(B2:B10)<br>→ Returns unique values from B2:B10                                                                  |
| COUNT / COUNTA / COUNTBLANK | Counts numbers, non-empty cells, or blank cells. | =COUNT(range) (numbers)<br>=COUNTA(range) (non-empty cells)<br>=COUNTBLANK(range) (blank cells) | =COUNT(B2:B10) → Counts numbers<br>=COUNTA(B2:B10) → Counts non-empty cells<br>=COUNTBLANK(B2:B10) → Counts blank cells |



**TIP:** Practice these functions with real data to build speed and confidence for your Excel interviews!

